

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

VIRAL OUTBREAKS

FEVER PITCH

By Sonali Acharjee

If there are rains, can viruses be far behind? The southwest monsoon, which hit India at the end of May, brought with it much-needed relief from the blistering summer, but also saw an alarming outbreak of a range of viral infections across the country. "Rain and high humidity are ideal conditions for the [breeding of] mosquitoes, who carry many of these viruses. On top of that, owing to high humidity, viruses transfer more easily between animals and livestock. Stagnant water, in particular, is the perfect breeding ground for viral outbreaks," says Dr Jatin Ahuja, senior consultant, infectious disease, Indraprastha Apollo Hospitals, New Delhi.

So while Gujarat has been reeling under the impact of the Chandipura virus (a relatively new strain of viral encephalitis, known to affect mostly children), Kerala has been battling the Nipah virus, swine flu has Mumbai, Pune and Rajasthan in its grip and West Bengal was put on high alert in June after the World Health Organization confirmed a case of human avian flu there, the first such in the country this year. The situation in Bengal seems to be under control since, but Maharashtra has seen outbreaks of Zika and dengue, as has Karnataka. Most of these viruses are old ones and, according to health experts, the sudden outbreaks are courtesy the changes in weather conditions.

SAVE CHANDIPURA, ALL THE VIRUSES ARE OLD. THE OUTBREAKS ARE COURTESY THE CHANGING WEATHER CONDITIONS

In July alone, there were 202,122 episodes of fever, 2,250 cases of dengue and 1,850 cases of mumps in Kerala, according to the state health department. Between January and July, there have been over 400,000 cases of other communicable diseases in the state. Besides their endemicity, experts accord the high numbers also to the state having among the best public health awareness, health data recording and referral systems in the country.

In Gujarat, acute encephalitis has already claimed about 66 lives since early June and, according to health experts, the Chandipura virus presently has the highest fatality rate amongst all the viral infections circulating in the country. The virus, once it infects a human, causes encephalitis, an infection where the brain becomes inflamed, potentially damaging tissue and causing a range of neurological symptoms, which include fever, headache, vomiting, seizures and altered consciousness.

"The virus also has a very short gestation stage of one or two days, so it is important to get tested as soon as possible. If left untreated, this is a dangerous disease and can even lead to death," adds Dr Ahuja. According to an article on the Indian Council of Medical Research website, the first clinical diagnosis in India of the older variant, Japanese encephalitis, was in 1955 in Tamil Nadu. Precautions include basic sanitation and hygiene, such as wearing of face masks, hand washing and social